

LOCAL NEWS

Waikato electric bike maker revs up



FTN founders and co-chief executives Luke Sinclair and Kendall Bristow.

NILE BIJOUX

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Hamilton's FTN Motion, builder of boutique electric two-wheelers, has launched its next model – the Streetdog80.

The bike gets its name from its top speed of 80kph, which means riders need a motorbike licence for it, rather than the car licence-level Streetdog Classic and its top speed of 50kph.

"The Streetdog80 is a significant step forward for us as a company," FTN Motion co-founder Kendall Bristow said.

"The extra speed allows users more freedom, and lets them access more roads around the country. We're proud to be building Streetdogs right here in New Zealand and growing the country's strong legacy as a manufacturer of world leading motorbikes."

A new, more powerful motor on the rear wheel produces a peak of 7.5kW (up from the 5kW of Boost power in the Classic) as well as new graphics and colour options. It uses the same battery so range does take a hit if you're going full throttle everywhere. Nonetheless, FTN claim between 60km and 80km between charges.

Demand for the Streetdog80 is already strong, with the first production run of 50 bikes fully reserved ahead of its official launch.

"It's great to see that consumers are really keen to get their hands on this bike," Bristow said.

"With congestion, parking problems and the price of fuel, people are increasingly looking for smarter ways to commute, and many are choosing the Streetdog as the answer."

The bike is simple to ride, featuring a PIN or tap-start system and an automatic, gear-free design that provides immediate acceleration and ease of use.

FTN has plans to expand to Australia this year, with 40 Streetdogs already pre-sold.

FTN's general manager of growth, sales and marketing Michel Roncara said that Australian orders were expected to fill the bulk of the 700-odd annual orders. The 80 will likely comprise a lot of these, because places like Sydney have more 60-80kph areas.

The production version of the 80 is, Roncara told me at the launch, largely the same as the beta version I rode last year. That means a nice, gentle torque curve but one that arcs out further than the Classic to enable that extra top speed. It also feels more natural in its power delivery - the Classic's motor had more to give but the software's fairly hard cutout point kept its speed down, whereas the 80s software tapers off more gently, which feels nicer to ride.

The new chassis is fantastic too. It's still a twin-cradle design, but it fully connects the top rail to either end. Previously the frame would stop about halfway into the storage box, with the remaining bit reinforced by carbon fibre. The extra steel only adds about 3kg to the total weight but it removes the flex the older Classics had, which gives you so much more confidence as a rider.

Pricing for the Streetdog80 kicks off at \$13,600. Customers configure their bike online, choosing their desired colours, upgrades and accessories.



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